

Q Why is my baby crying? Should I assume she is hungry?

Crying is a natural state for your baby, and is her first and main means of communication.

Your baby may not know why she's upset, she just knows that something is wrong. Your job is to figure out what that thing is. In the first days and weeks, hunger is often the reason for her cries; you may want to feed her if it has been a couple of hours since she was fed. As your baby grows and feedings become more spaced out, you may not want to offer a feeding instantly—in fact, if you do, she may expect to be fed every time you pick her up.

As you get to know your baby, you'll notice clues as to what's wrong. If your baby is fussing, perhaps rubbing her eyes, yawning, and looking glazed, she probably needs a nap. Babies can cry when overstimulated, whether they are feeling tired or because there is too much going on. Other reasons include wanting to change position, needing a diaper change, or feeling too hot or too cold. If she's been asleep, she may cry because she needs reassurance that you are close by. If she's uncomfortable, she may simply be craving the comfort and reassurance she feels when held in your arms.

If your baby is crying intensely (three hours a day or more) and won't be soothed, often at the same time each day, and maybe looks flushed, is clenching her fists, and drawing her legs up to her tummy while crying, she may have colic—the term used when otherwise healthy babies cry excessively. You should see your pediatrician so that he or she can rule out any other cause for her crying.

Q I love carrying my baby in a front pack, but will it make her too clingy?

Carrying your baby in a front pack, or "baby wearing," is comforting for mom, or dad, and baby. This closeness makes your baby feel secure and loved, and in turn confident you're there for her, so fears about clinginess are ungrounded. The sound of your heartbeat relaxes your baby, and you'll quickly pick up on feeding cues. Make sure your baby is safe in the pack. It should be tight enough to hold her securely and support her back, her face should be clear of the carrier fabric and her head close to yours, and her chin should not rest on her chest.

Q How can I comfort my fussing baby?

Sometimes comfort and closeness to you can be enough to soothe your baby and reassure her that all is well.

When you respond to your baby's cries with soft words, a gentle touch, and by keeping her close, she learns that she can trust you to recognize her needs and that the world is a safe place for her, and in the long run she

is likely to become more independent and confident. There's no right or wrong way to soothe your baby, and you and your baby will find techniques that work for you both.

SOOTHING TECHNIQUES

Experiment with different comforting methods to find the ones that work best for you and your baby.

» **Rhythm and motion** are naturally soothing to your baby, perhaps reminding her of her time in the uterus. Gently rocking or swaying your baby, or carrying her in a front pack, is reassuring, and being close to you makes her feel safe and secure. If crying is persistent, a trip around the block in the carriage or car may lull her to sleep, though you may not want her to become too dependent on these methods of soothing.

» **Sucking** is inherently comforting for your little one, so if hunger isn't the problem, she may enjoy sucking on your finger or a pacifier (though you may be avoiding pacifiers in the early weeks to avoid nipple confusion, see page 273).

» **White noise** can help your baby to switch off and zone out when she is overstimulated. The sound of the washing machine may remind your baby of swooshing noises in the uterus and be a comfort.

» **Whispering**, talking gently, singing a soothing lullaby, and smiling can all help to calm a grouchy baby, especially one who is just in need of a bit of company.

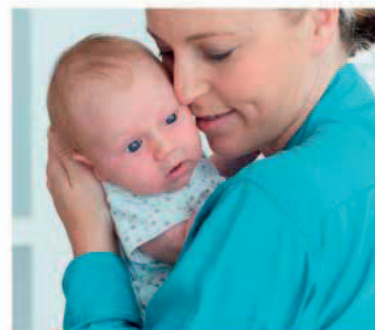
» **Rubbing your baby's back** while held upright, or while gently swaying her as she's held face down along your arm, may help if she has gas or is colicky.

» **Physical contact** is essential to your baby's well-being. Stroking her head and gently patting her back or bottom can be soothing, and if your baby has colic, a baby massage can help her to relax if she's receptive. Stroke her arms and legs, her palms, and the soles of her feet; then stroke her brow and, if comfortable for her, stroke her tummy in a clockwise motion.

If crying is persistent, occurs around the same time each day, and your baby is inconsolable, she may have colic. Talk to your pediatrician about ways to ease this.



Close to you Snuggled close, listening to your heartbeat, is naturally soothing for your baby.



A calm hold Older babies often enjoy being held upright as you move around.



Face down Some babies love to be held face down and gently rocked back and forth.